
KISSA KURSI KA

THE CASE OF THE MISSING FILM

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KISSA KURSI KA

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MY FIRST COVER STORY WAS ON SANJAY GANDHI, IN THE INFAMOUS *KISSA KURSI KA* CASE, WHERE HE WAS ACCUSED OF DESTROYING PRINTS OF THE 1975 FILM

hard-charging journalism, nothing like it had been seen in the Indian media space.

Post Emergency, we ran a series of cover stories on the inhuman treatment of political prisoners, mainly opposition leaders and their families, or journalists seen as a threat to the ruling dispensation. Being Delhi-based, we also met many of them personally to get first-hand accounts for the magazine. Every issue sold out and subscriptions soared. Aroon had taken over as Editor-in-Chief and his vision and ambition were contagious, pushing us to greater heights.

I remember me, Sunil and Mandira entering the former prime minister's house (Mrs Gandhi had lost the election to the ill-starred Janata Party). Sanjay Gandhi's wife Maneka was standing on the veranda. She rudely asked which media outlet we belonged to. On being told where we were from, Maneka shouted at the guard, "Those INDIA TODAY people, throw them out." To us, it meant the magazine had arrived.

In fact, my first cover story was on Sanjay Gandhi, in the infamous *Kissa Kursi Ka* case, where he was accused of destroying prints of the 1975 film, a spoof on authoritarian politics and state propaganda featuring characters that were thinly veiled caricatures of Mrs Gandhi and Sanjay. He would show up in court, surrounded by his praetorian guard, 'goons' we called them because they behaved as such. Climbing the narrow staircase, there was much pushing and shoving. At one point in the melee, I was almost face to face with Sanjay. He looked calm and composed, nothing like the man who, without any official status, had virtually ruled the country for 17 months, reduced ministers to minions, and almost destroyed India's constitutional foundations. Here he was, facing some justice at last, but after heated arguments, the petitioner, who had made the film *Kissa Kursi Ka* (*Tale of a Throne*), suddenly dropped the case, but it gave me my first prominent byline. I would go on to write many more cover stories, regular columns and major features, including satire, and travel the world covering wars, state visits and scandals. As the Red Bull tagline says: It (INDIA TODAY in this case) gave me wings.

What made the magazine unique was that it was written with flair and objectivity. The writing style and format were unique to the Indian media and the kind of professionalism and objectivity that was introduced and enforced by Aroon, who led from the front, made us the country's principal media source. Mohini Bhullar, as marketing head, would play a major role in its commercial success. That allowed us to attract the best journalistic talent. There was no dearth of subjects to cover during that first decade, from the political convulsions of the Janata Party, the return of Mrs Gandhi, to the rise of the middle class behind the wheel of a Maruti 800, and the sectarian churning which would have bloody consequences in the years ahead. Our coverage of the Bhopal Gas tragedy and the 1983 Nellie massacre established our reputation for investigative and hard-hitting journalism.

It was a great place to work; open, competitive and contemporary in every aspect, and sparing no expense to get the story and ensure it was fair and objective. In the time I was there (I left in 2010), INDIA TODAY followed no ideology except the basic journalistic creed of speaking truth to power. What endeared us to readers was that we were not just reporting the facts, we took a stand. The phenomenal success of the magazine had also to do with the names on the masthead. They represented the best that Indian journalism had to offer. Collectively, we combined to produce path-breaking journalism and set the standards for others to follow. December 1975 to October 2010 were the best years of my journalistic career and all I can say, looking back, is 'What a Ride'. ■

***— Dilip Bobb** was part of the original team that launched INDIA TODAY in 1975. He left the magazine as Managing Editor in 2010*